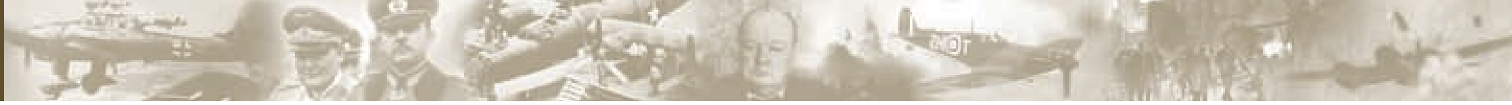




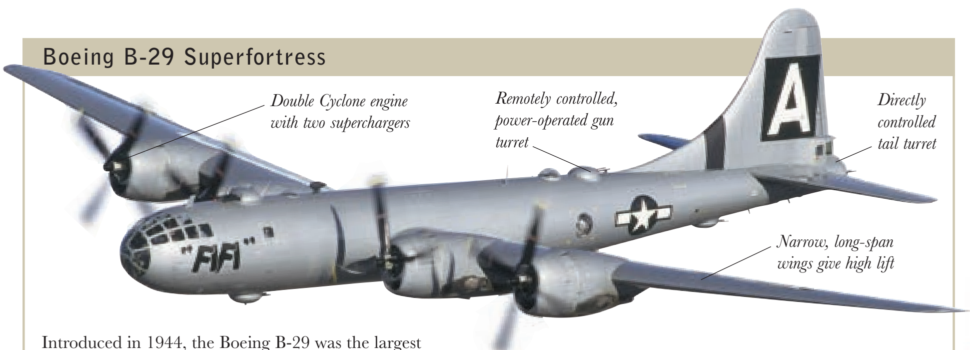
# WWII BOMBERS

**WWII BOMBER AIRCRAFT** were powerful machines, capable of delivering a far heavier punch than their WWI predecessors. Vulnerable to ground fire and enemy fighters, bombers relied on substantial firepower along with fighter escorts or night cover for their survival. The United States and Great Britain were committed to using bombers as a strategic weapon and invested heavily in long-range heavy bombers that could be used for mass-formation raids by day or by night. Their goal was to cripple the opposing war effort. However, the impact of the Allied bombing effort on German morale was limited, but the attacks on industry – particularly oil and communications – and cities, from April 1944 onward, eventually paid off, despite high losses. Japan suffered even more heavily under American air bombardment during 1944 and 1945.

**AVRO LANCASTERS**

*The Avro Lancaster was the most effective British heavy bomber, able to carry a bomb load of 14,000lb (6,350kg). It featured most notably in the German dam raids of 1943.* *See pages 240–41.*

## Boeing B-29 Superfortress




Introduced in 1944, the Boeing B-29 was the largest and technically most advanced bomber of the war. The B-29 was the ultimate long-range heavy bomber, responsible for dropping the atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki that helped end the war in the Pacific. The B-29's main weakness was found in its engines being prone to fire leading to engine failure and flying accidents rather than enemy fire.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **ENGINE** | 4 x 2,200hp Wright R-3350-23 Double Cyclone radial | | |
| **WINGSPAN** | 141ft 3in (43.1m) | **LENGTH** | 99ft (30.2m) |
| **TOP SPEED** | 357mph (603kph) | **CREW** | 10–14 |
| **ARMAMENT** | 12 x .5in machine guns; 1 x 20mm cannon; 20,000lb (9,000kg) bombload | | |

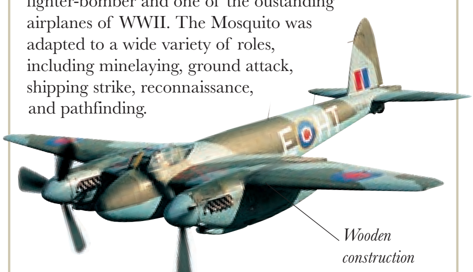
## Consolidated B-24J Liberator

This versatile aircraft was used as a bomber, transport, tanker, maritime patrol, reconnaissance, and antisubmarine aircraft. Built in larger numbers than any other US aircraft in history, its long range made it particularly useful in the Pacific theater.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **ENGINE** | 4 x 1,200hp Pratt & Whitney R-1830 Twin Wasp radial | | |
| **WINGSPAN** | 110ft (33.5m) | **LENGTH** | 67ft 2in (20.5m) |
| **TOP SPEED** | 300mph (507kph) | **CREW** | 12 |
| **ARMAMENT** | 10 x .5in machine guns; 8,800lb (3,990kg) bombload | | |

## de Havilland D.H.98 Mosquito B.16

The de Havilland Mosquito was a highly versatile fighter-bomber and one of the oustanding airplanes of WWII. The Mosquito was adapted to a wide variety of roles, including minelaying, ground attack, shipping strike, reconnaissance, and pathfinding.




| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **ENGINE** | 2 x 1,290hp Rolls-Royce Merlin 73 inline | | |
| **WINGSPAN** | 54ft 2in (16.5m) | **LENGTH** | 87ft 3in (26.6m) |
| **TOP SPEED** | 408mph (689kph) | **CREW** | 2 |
| **ARMAMENT** | 4,000lb (1,812kg) bombload | | |

## Handley Page Halifax II


Easy to fly, faster than the Wellington, and possessing a good range and bomb load, the Handley Page Halifax was the RAF's second four-engined bomber. Its only downside was its lack of defensive firepower, bringing heavy losses in raids. In 1942, the earlier variants were taken out of bomber command and given a new lease of life as minelayers and torpedo-bombers for coastal command.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **ENGINE** | 4 x 1,390hp Rolls-Royce Merlin XXII water-cooled inline | | |
| **WINGSPAN** | 104ft 2in (31.8m) | **LENGTH** | 70ft 1in (21.4m) |
| **TOP SPEED** | 282mph (477kph) | **CREW** | 7 |
| **ARMAMENT** | 9 x .303in Browning machine guns; 5,800lb (2,630kg) bombload | | |